

The AI Tell: Why Everyone Recognizes ChatGPT Copy

Free sample chapter — from 'Human-Sounding AI Copy' by Obed Cudjoe

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You've felt it reading an article, an ad, a LinkedIn post: a certain smoothness. Balanced sentences. A tidy structure. And absolutely nothing that sounds like a human made a choice. That's the AI tell - and once you see it, you can't unsee it.

The tell is not one thing. It's a cluster of tells. The em-dash that shows up three times per paragraph. The 'it's not just X, it's Y' construction that appears in every AI-written piece on the internet. The rhythm that never varies - long sentence, short sentence, long sentence, perfectly alternating. The total absence of anything specific: no odd detail, no unfashionable opinion, no sentence that a hundred other writers wouldn't write.

Why does this happen? Language models are trained to predict the most likely next word. The most likely word is the average word. The most likely structure is the average structure. Left to their own devices, they produce the average of all copy ever written - which is why AI copy feels like it was written by a committee of nobody.

The good news: the average is avoidable. Models are capable of surprising, specific, opinionated writing - but they need to be pushed off the average. That push comes in two forms: constraints that forbid the average moves, and inputs that give them something specific to work with. Both are in your control.

This book is the control panel. Chapter two builds the voice brief that teaches AI to sound like your brand. Chapter three is the editing pass that removes the tells from anything already written. Chapter four gives you prompt patterns for ads, emails and landing pages that start specific and stay specific.

The goal is not to disguise AI writing as human writing. The goal is writing that happens to be good - and good writing, whether a human or a model drafted it, is specific, rhythmical and a little bit strange. You're about to learn how to get there on purpose.

Action steps: (1) Find one piece of AI-generated copy you've published. (2) Circle every em-dash, every 'it's not just X' and every sentence that could appear in any article about any topic. (3) You now have your first editing list.